The Butcher's Wife Poems

"Shelter", "The Butcher's Wife" and "My Name Repeated on the Lips of the Dead"

By Louise Erdrich

INTRODUCTION

It is the turn of the century in a German-American immigrant settlement. Mary Kröger marries the butcher, Otto, after his first wife -- who is also Mary's best friend -- dies, asking her to take care of Otto and their four sons. Shelter from "The Butcher's Wife" section of Jacklight by Louise Erdrich

Shelter

My four adopted sons in photographs
wear solemn black. Their faces comprehend
their mother's death, an absensce in a well
of empty noise, and otto strange and lost.
Her name was Mary also, Mary Kroger.
Two of us have lived and one is gone.
Her hair was blond; it floated back in wings,
and still you see her traces in the boys:

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bright hair and long, thin, knotted woman's hands.
I knew here, Mary Kroger, and we were bosom friends.
All graves are shelters for our mislaid twins.

Otto was for many years her husband,
and that's the way I always thought of him.
I nursed her when she sickened and the cure
feel through at Rochester. The healing bath
that dropped her temperature, I think, too fast.
I was in attendance at her death:
She sent the others out. She rose and gripped my arm
and tried to make me promise that I'd care
for Otto and the boys. I had to turn away
as my own mother had when her time came.
How fe do not return in memory
and make us act in ways we can't explain.
I could not lie to ease her, living, dying.
All graves are full of such accumulation.
And yet, the boys were waiting in New York
to take the first boat back to Otto's folks
in Germany, prewar, dar powers were at work,

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And Otto asked me on the westbound bus
to marry him. I could not tell him no --
We help our neighbors out. I loved him though
It took me several yeas to know I did
from that first time he walked in to deliver
winter food. Through Father Adler's kitchen,
He shouldered half an ox like it was bread
and looked at me too long for simple greeting.
This is how our lives complete themselves,
as effortless as weather, circles blaze
in ordinary days, and through our waking selves
they reach, to touch our true and sleeping speech.

So I took up with Otto, took the boys
and watched for them, and made their daily bread
from what the grocer gave them in exchange
for helping hi. It's hard to tell you how
they soon became so precious I got sick
from worry, and woke up for two months straight
And had to check them, sleeping, in their beds,
and had to watch and see each breathe or move

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before I could regain my sleep again.
All graves are pregnant with our nearest kin.

TRANSITION

Lives were short-lived at the turn of the century and Otto soon dies as well, leaving Mary, the Butcher's Wife a widow – a widow who once loved her husband, but who seems to have difficulty mourning the passing her drunken spouse.

The Butcher's Wife

1

Once, my braids swung heavy as ropes.
Men feared them like the gallows.
Night fell
When I combed them out.
No one could see me in the dark.

Then I stood still
Too long and the braids took root.
I wept, so helpless.
The braids tapped deep and flourished.

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A man carne by with an ox on his shoulders.
He yoked it to my apron
And pulled me from the ground.
From that time on I wound the braids around my head
So that my arms would be free to tend him.

2

He could lift a grown man by the belt with his teeth.
In a contest, he'd press a whole hog, a side of beef.
He loved his highballs, his herring, and the attentions of women.
He died pounding his chest with no last word for anyone.

The gin vessels in his face broke and darkened. I traced them
Far from that room into Bremen on the Sea.
The narrow streets twisted down to the piers.
And far off, in the black, rocking water, the lights of trawlers
Beckoned, like the heart's uncertain signals,
Faint, and final.

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3

Of course I planted a great, full bush of roses on his grave.
Who else would give the butcher roses but his wife?
Each summer, I am reminded of the heart surging from his vest,
Mocking all the high stern angels
By pounding for their spread skirts.

The flowers unfurl, offering themselves,
And I hear his heart pound on the earth like a great fist,
Demanding another round of the best wine in the house.
Another round, he cries, and another round all summer long,
Until the whole damn world reels toward winter drunk.

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TRANSITION

After Otto dies Mary is left to deal with Sherriff Rudy J. V. Jacklitch, whose courting she does not encourage, until he crashes his truck and dies cursing her. Nevertheless, Mary hears HER name destroyed by the townspeople. My Name Repeated on the Lips of the Dead

My Name Repeated on the Lips of the Dead

Last night, my dreams were full of Otto's best friends.
I sat in the kitchen, wiping the heavy silver,
and listened to the losses, tough custom, and fouled
accounts
of the family bootlegger, county sheriff:
Rudy J.V. Jacklitch, who sat just beside me,
wiping his wind-cracked hands
with lard smeared on a handkerchief.

Our Pekinese-poodle went and darkened his best wool
trousers, and he leapt up, yelling for a knife!

These are the kinds of friends

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I had to tend in those days:
great, thick men, devouring
Fleisch, *Spaetzle*, the very special
potato salad for which I dice
onions so fine they are invisible.

Rudy J.V. Jacklitch was a bachelor, but he cared
for his mother, a small spider of a woman – all fingers,
She cove red everything, from the kettle to the radio,
with a doily. The whole house
dripped with lace, frosting fell
from each surface in fantastic shapes.
When Otto died, old Rudy came by
with a couple jugs for the mourners' supper.
He stayed on past midnight, every night the month after
he would bring me a little something
to put the night away.

After a short while I knew his purpose.
His glance slipped as the evening
and the strong drink wore on.

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playing cribbage I always won,
a sure sign he was distracted.
I babbled like a talking bird,
never let him say the words
I knew were in him.

Then one night he came by,
already loaded to the gills,
rifle slung in the back window
of his truck: *Going out*
to shoot toads. He was peeved
with me. I'd played him all wrong>
He said his mother *knew just what I was*.

The next thing I heard that blurred night
was that Rudy drove his light truck
through the side of a barn,
and that among the living
he stayed long enough
to pronounce my name, like a curse
through the rage and foam of his freed blood.

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So I was sure, for a time and a time after,
That Rudy carried
my name down to hell on his tongue
like a black coin.

I would wake, in the deepest of places,
and hear my name called.
My name like a strange new currency they read:
Mary Kroger
with its ring of the authentic
when dropped
or struck between their fingers.
How I feared to have it whispered in their mouths!

Mary Kroger
growing softer and thinner
till it dissolved
like a wafer under all that polishing.

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